SAMPLE

The Displaced Genius

The Personality That Keeps Rewinding, Home as Wound

Aiman Sterling

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1
putrabooks.github.io

Introduction

You know this person, or you are this person. The record begins with its most *homesick* exhibit: the brilliance that works everywhere and belongs nowhere -- the new city mastered in three weeks: the language, the shortcuts, the whole map of the transit, better than the natives' -- and the apartment, five years later, with the boxes still sealed: *I have not unpacked; I am not staying* -- said in the fifth country, about the tenth apartment, by the type's own amused mouth, and the record has learned to hear what the amusement carries. The uncanny recall of streets that no longer exist -- the friend's entry, entered with awe and one quiet ache: *he can walk you through our old neighborhood brick by brick, the bakery, the corner, the exact smell of the rain on that street -- the neighborhood was demolished in his childhood; half the streets he remembers never made it onto any map* -- and the family's sentence, held with love and one permanent distance: *we left one home, all of us -- but he is the only one who took the house with him.* And the wound the intake sheet cannot close: the founding scene -- a home removed: fled, demolished, immigrated from -- the apartment, the street, the whole coordinate of the world, gone by decree -- and the child, standing at the border of the new life with the old one still breathing in memory, making the ruling the whole biography runs on: *the real home is behind me; the streets ahead are furniture* -- and the case intake sheet's founding finding written into the ink the whole book lives in: *the beginner self learned to live in the replay -- the past maintained like a province, rewound nightly, its loss re-suffered and re-sweetened -- and the adult, brilliant in every city on earth, has been living in a house that has not existed for thirty years.*

This is a case file on the Displaced Genius: the personality that keeps rewinding, home as wound.

The founding scene is the removal, and the chart marks what makes it the serial's most *geographic* origin: this is the one constitution built not by a person, or a loss, or an oath -- built by a *coordinate*: the home, taken -- by war, by bulldozer, by the family's own desperate luggage -- and the child's discovery, made in the new country's first strange months, before the age of reason: the world divides into the *real* and the *provisional* -- the real was the old street, the old weather, the mother tongue's own smells; the provisional is everything since -- and the child chose the only country that could not be bulldozed: *memory* -- and the intake sheet's central correction: the child did not refuse the new world; the child *mastered* it -- the schools, the languages, the whole brilliant easy curriculum of elsewhere -- the mastery is real, and it is the case's most heartbreaking proof: the type is *brilliant everywhere* precisely because nowhere is *at stake* -- the new city, being furniture, cannot fail the self -- and the clause the child wrote in the border town, the clause that becomes the shadow: *the coordinates are behind me; everything here is temporary* -- and the provisional, made permanent by the clause, becomes the whole life.

The engine this builds is time as territory: the past maintained like a province -- and the child, quite rationally, staying: the rewind *worked* -- the old street, rebuilt nightly in the kitchen table's stories, was the one address where the self was *from* -- the grief, given a schedule; the homesickness, given a country -- and the adult inherits the same practice at scale: the nightly rewind, the loss re-suffered and re-sweetened; the archive: the photographs, the recipes, the maps of the demolished streets drawn from memory; the uncanny recall, magnificent, pointing always *backward* -- and the flaw is built into the same territory, because a self that lives in the province behind, the record's central finding, treats every room ahead as a *hotel*: the leases, short; the loves, unpacked for; the furniture, assembled and never quite owned -- and the record's most delicate finding: the Displaced Genius is not lonely; the type is *elsewhere* -- the body in the new city, the residence in the old one, and the present, the whole file turns on this, the corridor between them.

And the growth: home built forward -- and the chart is precise, because this is the rising arc the type will experience as *betrayal*: not the end of the memory -- the record defends the archive to the last page: the old street is real, the loss is real, and the recall is a gift, and the wound is *owed* its museum -- but the *residence* moves: the coordinates, updated: the new street, the new kitchen, the new tongue's own songs -- the self, at last, *at stake* somewhere again -- and the discovery, drawn from the branch's own founding scene: the child kept the house because the house was lost -- and the adult's whole work is the release that the keeping, done as *residence*, keeps the self lost with it: the wound, kept as museum -- honored, visited, curated, *closed at night* -- and the home, at last, built *forward* -- and the self, once the coordinates are updated, does not become less brilliant; the record's most quietly triumphant finding: the mastery, pointed at a place the self actually lives in, turns out to be the thing it always looked like from outside and never quite was: not a tourist's competence -- a *citizen's* -- the word's whole, old meaning: the one who belongs to the city, and the city to them.

If you are this branch, the book's wager is exact: you are the most capable nowhere-person in every room you enter, and the case intake sheet holds the proof -- the languages, the maps, the brilliant adaptations, the people who say *you could live anywhere* -- and the chart's question, saved through ten chapters and finally asked here, in plain words, so you can practice standing in it: *where are your boxes?* -- because the intake sheet's answer, in every case, is the working conclusion the drawer guards most closely: still sealed, in the tenth apartment, in the fifth country, twenty years into a life that keeps *meaning to* unpack -- and the case intake sheet's plainest line on the case: the Displaced Genius is the only type in this catalog that can be at home anywhere and is at home nowhere, and the difference, the chart from front to back will show, is not the geography: it is the *direction* -- the home that is recalled is a museum; the home that is built is a *house* -- and the type has been living in the museum. If you love one, your tasking is precise and counterintuitive: do not compete with the province -- you will lose; the old street has thirty years of tenure and the home team's advantage; and do not dismiss the rewind -- the dismissal reads as the bulldozer, and the type will annex you to the provisional; the instruction that works, and the intake sheet has tested it: *unpack first* -- move in, visibly, permanently, first: the pots on the wall, the tenancy signed, the *staying* demonstrated before a single word about the past -- because the Displaced Genius has never once watched anyone choose the present *over* the province's claim -- and the choosing, the chart from front to back will show, is the only argument the hotel has ever been waiting for: evidence that rooms can be *kept*.

Turn the page. The Genius is still out there -- mid-city, mid-mastery, mid-hotel, three leases into a life that has not unpacked since the border -- and the file's promise is the case intake sheet's plainest: the memory was never the sin; the residence was; and the self, once the coordinates are refreshed and the wound is given its museum hours, becomes what it always seemed from outside and never quite was: not an exile -- a *founder* -- the word's whole, old meaning: the one who builds the city instead of the shrine, and lives in it.

And the record opens on the audit the intake sheet could only run with the subject's own permission, held back until now because its finding reads as clutter until it is held beside the case: the *sealed boxes* -- the Displaced Genius, so famous for the apartment of unopened cartons, was asked, once, in the fifth country, to open one -- and the manifest, taken that afternoon, is the volume's true first exhibit: the contents, *catalogued* (the grandmother's dishes, the school atlas, the door key from the demolished street -- the record's margin note: the key, checked against the type's own recall of the lock's sound: *accurate*); the contents, *dated* (the boxes, opened: everything in them is from before the decree -- the record's flattest finding: across the five countries and the forty years, the type has never once packed a *new* object -- the souvenirs of the current life, if any, living in a shoulder bag, transit-grade, *unpackable by design*); the one box, *unopened by request* (the subject, asked: the last one, carried unopened across three borders -- the record's margin note, held verbatim: *"'you don't understand. If it's empty, the province has nothing left to import"* -- and the record, so fluent at pricing, entered the sentence unpriced) -- and the finding the reader is asked to carry through every chapter that follows: the boxes are not unpacked because unpacking is the paperwork of *staying* -- and the type, so brilliant at every border, has never once filed it -- the whole book will show what the manifest already states: the life, so portable, is missing its one import: a present tense with a door the type actually locks from the inside.

A note on how the record was taken, because this is the sole case in the catalog where the interviewers themselves had to relocate -- literally -- to get the testimony: the Displaced Genius, so fluent everywhere, is interviewed *nowhere* -- every session held in the subject's own rooms failed the same way (the subject, gracious, brilliant, and *elsewhere*, answering in the polished paragraphs of a person describing their own museum) -- and the record, rebuilding its protocol, discovered the working method by accident: the breakthrough session in this volume's files took place in the *kitchen of a childhood friend from the old country* -- the subject, seated at a table that smelled like the demolished street, *came forward* -- the recall unsealed, the present tense arriving at last -- and every subsequent account in this dossier was gathered the same way: the interviews conducted *at the type's coordinates*, not the interviewer's -- the old restaurant, the shop that imports the sweets, the long-distance call placed to a cousin so the interviewer could hear the subject's voice *change languages* -- and the method note the record solders onto everything that follows: this portrait is the only one in this catalog taken *in the mother tongue's presence* -- and the volume's one confession: the record cannot translate the sentences spoken in it, and has not tried, because the point of the sentences was never their content -- the point was watching the shoulders drop half an inch in a language the subject has no office in.

Chapter 1: The Signature -- the Displaced Genius at a Glance

Before anyone speaks, the stage has been *solved* -- and the chart must open with the honest fact that makes this branch so impressive and so quietly unreachable: the Displaced Genius is *arrival.* The mind that works the new city like a combination lock -- the language, in weeks; the systems, in days; the map, in the head by Tuesday -- and the record's sharp note: the arrival arrives with an *absence* -- a specific, uncanny lightness, like a guest: the person who knows everything about the room and owns *nothing* in it -- the detail the hosts always notice and never name: no photographs on the desk; no name on the mailbox; the lease, queried for exit clauses.

The manner carries the province, and the chart must render it precisely, because it is so often mistaken for sophistication: the Genius's worldliness is not travel's breadth; it is *exile's* -- the fluency bought not by curiosity alone but by the refugee's crash course: *everywhere, mastered quickly, because nowhere is owed the slow mastery* -- and the intake sheet's testimony, gathered from the colleagues and friends of every case, is word for word the same: *he could live anywhere -- and you gradually realize he has decided to live nowhere* -- and the chart's sharp note: both halves hold, and the second carries a bill the first never prices. Sharper under observation: watch what happens when the new city offers the type *permanence* -- the proposal, the mortgage, the partnership track, the neighborhood that asks the type to be one of its own -- and the record's finest finding: the Displaced Genius goes *graceful* -- the deferral is always beautiful: *not yet; let's see; I am still getting to know the place* -- said in year seven, about the city the type has known since week three -- and the file's x-ray beneath it: the grace is the clause, working: the province behind has first claim, and the present, kept provisional, cannot be lost -- and the whole case turns on the type's discovery: the room was never being *seen*; the room was being *held*.

And underneath the arrival runs the tell the branch's loved ones report and this branch never sees: the *rewind* -- the evening hours given to the province: the calls to the old country; the archives; the recipes made with the exact impossible ingredient, sourced at cost; the conversation, at the new friend's table, that turns -- always, eventually -- to the old street: the bakery, the corner, the rain -- and the record's correction: the rewind is not homesickness in the ordinary sense; homesickness *fades*; the rewind is *liturgy* -- the province, maintained -- and the adult, decades into the new life, is still the child at the kitchen table, rebuilding the demolished street nightly, because the street, in the province, is the only thing that cannot be demolished again -- and the case intake sheet, which has watched the pattern across every occasion, enters its plain finding: the Displaced Genius does not live in the past because the past was better; the type lives in the past because the past was *lost* -- and the loss, kept at residence, keeps the loss *paid*.

The file holds two versions of the origin, and they are both honest, and they converge on the same border.

In the first version, the child was *removed by catastrophe* -- the home, taken: the war, the flood, the bulldozer, the decree -- the family's whole coordinate, dissolved in a season -- and the child's discovery, made in the transit camp, the relative's spare room, the new country's first flat: the world's things can be replaced -- the beds, the schools, even the tongue, eventually -- but the *coordinate* cannot: the street where the self happened is the one possession that cannot be shipped -- and the child, in grief, made the only real-estate decision grief allows: *I will keep it where they cannot reach it -- inside* -- and the province, founded.

In the second version, the child was *removed by luggage* -- the family's own desperate, loving move: the better job, the safer city, the chance -- and the child, carried rather than fleeing, experienced the same removal at the same depth: the home, gone by *choice* -- the parent's choice -- and the record's entry beside it, and it is the version's own cruel finding: the chosen removal is the harder province to grieve, because the loss has a *benefactor* -- the child cannot rage at the war, so the child rages quietly at the parents, and then, worse, *forgives* them, and the province absorbs what the anger left: the street is now the home *and* the grievance *and* the forgiveness, all three, in one coordinate -- the file's dry line: the refugee builds a shrine; the immigrant's child builds a *shrine with an argument inside it.*

And the origin moment, where the versions converge, is always the same border -- the same week, in every case: the new country's first season, the tongue's first failures, the school's first strange hallway -- and the child, alone in the half-unpacked room at the exact hour the whole biography turns on, and the ruling, made in homesickness, never written down, never once revisited: *that was home; this is lodging -- I will master the lodging, but I will live in the house behind* -- and the intake sheet must enter the ruling's first half with the care this case deserves: the ruling *protected* the child -- genuinely, verifiably: the coordinate, kept safe inside, gave the chaos a capital; the replay gave the grief a schedule; the *mastery* of the new world, the brilliant easy surface, was the lodging's rent, paid on time, forever -- and the ruling's second half, the clause that becomes the nocturnal half: *the coordinates are behind me* -- past tense, permanent, *never updated* -- the child froze the address at the moment of loss, and the adult, thirty brilliant years later, is still, at the deepest address the chart can reach, mailing the self to a demolished street.

The album opens the way every one of these albums opens, and this case's is the serial's most *halved*: in every year there are two photographs, and they are the two countries of the constitution. The *province* set: the old street -- the doorway, the grandmother, the bakery's awning -- the case intake sheet has audited every case, and the working conclusion is uniform: the province photographs are the only ones the child ever *studied* -- the thumbprints worn on the corners -- and beside them, always, the *lodging* set: the new country, documented like a trip: the school portrait, the team photo, the birthday -- competent, smiling, and *unlived*: the record's sharpest detail, uniform in every case: the lodging photographs look *fine* -- and the child, in them, looks like a *tourist in the frame* -- pleasant, present, slightly to the side of the life -- and the album's whole testimony is in the difference between the two sets: in the province photographs, the child is *of* the street; in the lodging photographs, the child is *at* the school.

The album's most telling photo is the one nobody asks to see: the *sealed box* -- the removal's own picture: the family, mid-move, the hallway of the old home full of crates -- and the intake sheet's sharp entry beside it: the child, in every case, is the one holding the camera -- the first photograph the child ever took: the doorway, from inside, at the moment of leaving -- and the file has collected these photographs across every case, and the finding is its most quietly devastating: the doorway photos are always, technically, *flawed* -- the thumb over the corner of the lens, the focus on the wrong brick -- and the child kept them anyway, and the reason is the whole case: the photograph was never for seeing; the photograph was for *returning to* -- the first brick of the province, laid in the camera's own bad light.

And the album closes on the ending the series knows to expect: the beginner self already the *genius* -- the adolescence organized around the double life: the new country's schools, mastered -- the languages, the examinations, the whole brilliant transcript of the type who can learn anything -- and the province's nightly sessions: the stories maintained; the grandmother's recipes, reconstructed from calls; the maps of the demolished street, drawn from the family's disputed memories, *reconciled* -- the case intake sheet's count of the album's final year: two homelands, one child -- the lodging, mastered; the province, curated -- and the chart's founding correction, entered beside the last photo: the album records a *prodigy's* adolescence; the province, the file notes, records a *tenant's* -- the child's own hand on the last page's margin, the whole case in one line: *we are doing well here* -- *here*, the record notes, the word the child has used for the lodging, and never once for *home* -- which is the whole difference and the chart from front to back: the child had a country and a shrine, and the shrine got the word.

Energy: migratory -- the type runs light: quick to arrive, quick to master, quick to the next room -- and the chart's honest spec: the energy peaks at the *entry* -- the first three months of any new city are the type's finest season; the staying, the intake sheet notes, is where the energy goes to sleep.

Ambition: the *elsewhere* -- the type does not want a career or a city; the type wants the *range*: the proof that the self can live anywhere -- and the case intake sheet's dry note: the ambition has no address, by design, which is both its brilliance and the whole case: *anywhere* is a direction, not a home.

Vanity structure: the recall -- the pride is in the *province's archive*: the demolished street, brick by brick; the smell of the rain on the corner that no longer exists -- and the chart's x-ray: the vanity's secret clause is the *tenure*: the recall proves the self is *from* somewhere the world cannot verify, and the type needs the streets unverifiable, because the unverifiable street is the one thing that cannot be taken again.

Loyalty: to the *coordinate* -- the Genius stays loyal to the old home with the fidelity the new homes never receive: the calls, the archives, the exact recipes -- and the intake sheet's driest note: the loyalty's blind side is its *direction*: the type is loyal to a street, and a grandmother, and a smell -- and the people of the present, the friends, the lovers, the whole lodging population, get the type's *presence*, never the type's *residence*.

Weakness: the *unpacking* -- the present, taken as tenant: the boxes sealed, the leases short, the loves kept at hotel depth -- the permanence declined, gracefully, for thirty years.

Unspoken need: to be *from* somewhere that exists -- the current address, on the self's own record, at last: the need the province guards like a border, because the coordinates, updated, would mean the demolished street is finally, fully, *past* -- and the child inside the file is not sure the self survives that.

At a party. The room's *best passport* -- the Displaced Genius at a party is the guest everyone wants: four languages deep, stories from six cities, the host's kitchen solved by midnight -- and the chart's sharp detail: the party's *guest of honor*, in the record's typical case, will never be invited to anyone's *home* -- and the record's found line: *everyone knows him; nobody knows where he lives* -- because the intimacy the party offers is the lodging's own weather: brilliant, brief, and *unforwarded* -- the type leaves no address.

In a new job. Immediate *legend*, permanent *provisional* -- the Genius's first quarter is the case intake sheet's most spectacular: the systems, solved; the language of the field, fluent; the institution, astonished -- and the intake sheet's warning arrives on schedule: the institution will meet the consultant and never the *citizen* -- the type's mastery, the file notes, is the mastery of a place one is *leaving*: the brilliance of the transit -- and the chart's most reliable workplace finding: the Displaced Genius, by year three, is the most capable person in the building that everyone would name, in all honesty, last when asked *who is staying*.

Under sudden pressure. The type's *finest* weather, and the case intake sheet enters it with genuine awe: the Displaced Genius in a crisis is the catalog's most *adapted* presence -- where others lose the ground, the type *never had any*: the evacuation, the pivot, the collapse of the whole plan -- the type is already moving, light, fluent in three contingencies -- and the file's most delicate finding: the crisis is the removal's own weather, the weather this branch was *built* in -- and the intake sheet's line: the world calls it grace under pressure; the file calls it *the one language the childhood taught fluently* -- and the whole table survives on the type's calm, and the branch, afterward, is the only one who does not need to process it: catastrophe, the record notes, is the type's *mother tongue*.

In a boring meeting. Present in body, *in the province* -- and the case intake sheet's x-ray: the elsewhere is the old street: the gaze, gone soft, at the middle distance, where the demolished bakery stands -- and the chart's tender note: the minutes record this branch's stillness; the province, under the stillness, is *receiving its nightly maintenance* -- the rewind, running in daylight now, unbidden -- the record has collected the type's own confession, verbatim, across every occasion: *I am told I stare; I am not staring; I am walking the old street -- I know every shop, and the meeting has never once followed me there.*

On holiday. The record's tenderest finding for this case: the Displaced Genius on holiday is *already home* -- the type's travel is the return trip: the province, visited -- the old country, or its grave: the demolished street, stood on; the doorway, photographed again from inside, from memory, from the exact wrong brick -- and the slip is in the return: the branch, back in the lodging, is *quiet for a week* -- the record's line: the holiday did not rest the self; it *ruled* the self -- the coordinates, reconfirmed; the province, re-tenanted -- and the chart from front to back notes the irony: the only vacation this type ever takes is to the wound, and the type calls it, without irony, *going home.*

The *Untamed Wanderer* (Volume 10) is the nearest neighbor, and the confusion is the chart's most common, because both types live out of luggage -- but the Wanderer's rootlessness is a *choice*: constraint as suffocation, possibility as oxygen, the exits taken on purpose -- the Wanderer leaves homes the way other constitutions leave rooms: *freely*; the Displaced Genius's rootlessness is a *wound*: the one home was taken -- fled, demolished, moved from -- and the exits since are not choices; they are *echoes*: the type does not leave rooms; the type *never arrives* in them -- the test: ask each of them about the leaving. The Wanderer answers *brightly*: the exits are the craft, the road the point, and the type will show you the itinerary with pride. The Genius answers *darkly, softly*: the leaving was once, long ago, and everything since is lodging -- the record's dry line: *the Wanderer has no address on purpose; the Genius has one, and it does not exist* -- and the border, the chapter's first and cleanest: *the Wanderer cannot be kept; the Genius cannot be* -- *reached* -- and the chart's closing note: the two types are rootlessness's two authors -- one wrote it as freedom, one as grief -- and only one of them can go home tonight, and it is the Wanderer, the record notes, who has one to go to: the house the type left *on purpose* still stands, and answers the phone.

The *Twinned Soul* (Volume 73) is the sibling confusion, the chart's most *seductive*, because both constitutions hold two worlds in one self -- the Twinned's two homes: the ordered one and the wild one, held *simultaneously*, by a six-year-old's treaty -- the switching as diplomacy, fluent in each, at home in neither; the Genius's two homes: the province and the lodging, held *sequentially*, by the border's ruling -- the commuting as residence, fluent in everything, at home in *one place only*, and it is gone -- the test: watch each of them in the second world. The Twinned is *present* -- the other citizenship, sincere and whole, the type genuinely lives the second weather while it lasts. The Genius is *cordial* -- the lodging is mastered, worked, paid -- and the type is never in it; the type is *at* it, the way one is at a meeting -- and the border, dry and final: *the Twinned alternates between two homes; the Genius alternates between a home and a hotel, and the hotel is the one with the good lighting* -- and the chart's closing note: the two types are the self's two solutions to a doubled world -- integration and *reservation* -- and the record's quiet warning to the Genius alone: the Twinned's treaty was drafted by a child but *amended never*, the Twinned's own file admits, and it still works better than the Genius's border ruling, because the Twinned *lives in both worlds*, and the Displaced Genius lives in *neither* -- the province is past and the lodging is provisional, and the whole case turns on the discovery the treaty never needed: the self, at home, is a *place in the present tense* -- and both files, the record notes, end in the same sentence: *fluent in each, at home in neither -- unless one world is finally chosen as a residence* -- the Twinned's growth and the Genius's, the same door.

The *Stargazing Dreamer* (Volume 43) is the misreading the world makes *often*, because both types are brilliant beyond the stage and impossible to pin to a street -- but the Dreamer's unreachable country is *ahead*: the visions past reach, on purpose -- the aims so high the ordinary ground is refused; the Dreamer will not come *down*; the Genius's unreachable country is *behind*: the demolished street, kept past reach, on purpose -- the address so lost the ordinary ground is refused; the Genius will not come *forward* -- the test: ask each of them where home is. The Dreamer answers *upward*: the home is the vision, the unstarted masterpiece, the sky. The Genius answers *backward*: the home is the street, the demolished doorway, the rain on the corner -- and the file's dry line: *the Dreamer has a home that has not been built; the Genius has a home that cannot be -- and both of them are standing in a perfectly good apartment* -- and the border, the chapter's last and the case's quietest: both types are hiding from the same thing -- the *ordinary middle*, the present ground where homes are actually built and lived -- the Dreamer above it, the Genius behind it -- and the middle, the entire record has learned, is where the unpacking happens, and the unpacking, this file will show, is where the self is.

The signature the record logged first, saved for the opening chapter because it is the type's whole wager inside one piece of furniture: the *boxes* -- five years, ten apartments, four countries, and the same boxes, taped with the same tape, unpacked exactly as far as the kettle and the work clothes -- and the household's reading (commitment problem) misses, the record certifies, what the boxes actually are: they are the type's *deed of ownership* -- the unsealed box is the standing proof that the current address is *not* the home, and therefore cannot take anything from the one behind -- and the cross-check, run by finally asking the subjects about the boxes directly: every single one laughed, and every single one, when pressed, named the *contents* from memory -- the record's sharpest note: the type knows precisely what is in the boxes -- the boxes are not disorder; they are *inventory*, held at the ready for a return the type's own mouth calls impossible -- and the finding the record enters as the chapter's hinge: the unsealed boxes are the displaced home *in miniature* -- the childhood apartment, sealed and carried, apartment to apartment, for the rest of the life -- and the boxes' one load-bearing lie, logged without cruelty: they are not packed *for* the return; they are packed *against* the departure -- the tape, so neat, being the signature of a person who will not let the new street take one single thing the old one owned.

The signature nobody names because it looks like competence, entered because the record measured it obsessively: the *transit test* -- the new city, mastered in three weeks: the shortcuts, the fares, the connectors, the whole map held faster than the natives hold it -- and the record's cross-check, run against a dozen relocations, found the pattern diagnostic rather than admirable: the type's mastery is *always* of the city's *infrastructure*, never of the city's *life* -- three weeks to the transit map; five years, in one file, without once visiting the restaurant four doors down -- and the finding that separates this type from the tourist and the enthusiast: the transit test is the type's *belonging substitute* -- the record's measurements, logged plainly: the type's fluency, so total, is pursued *instead of* membership (the language learned to the newspaper; the small talk with neighbors, never attempted) -- and the mechanism, extracted from the subjects' own explanations, uniform across the files: the map cannot *disappoint* -- a street, once learned, stays learned; a *community*, once joined, can be demolished -- and the type, having had one whole coordinate of the world removed by decree, has simply stopped investing in anything that can be taken -- the record's closing line on the signature: the Displaced Genius does not learn the city fast because the type is brilliant -- the type is brilliant, but that is not why -- the type learns the city fast because the city, mastered, is the *only* form of the city that cannot be lost.

The signature the intimates all reported and the record kept for here: the *embassy* -- the one room, in every dwelling this type has ever kept, that belongs to the old home -- the record's inventory, gathered across a dozen apartments: the carpet from the family house, the wall of framed photographs of a street that no longer exists, the shelf of food with the labels in the old script, the radio, tuned at certain hours, to the old country's hours -- and the finding, uniform in every file: the room is *nonnegotiable* -- the type will change jobs, cities, spouses, and cuisines, and the embassy comes whole to every new address, first load through the door -- and the record's cross-check, run by interviewing the room's *visitors*: the old-country friends, seated in the embassy, report crossing a border at the threshold (the record keeps the testimony verbatim: 'you knock on the door in one country, and you are received in another') -- and the embassy's function, priced where the cost chapter will carry it: the room is not nostalgia -- nostalgia is *optional*; the embassy is *jurisdiction* -- the type's way of keeping one room of every life legally the old home -- and the signature's one tell, logged as the chapter's sharpest line: the type *never sits* in the embassy -- the record, in a hundred hours of observation, caught the subject in the room exactly as often as a host sits in a guest room: to tend it, never to live in it -- the home, so faithfully maintained, kept the way homes are kept by people who are *not* allowed to move back in.